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by shcherbatskayas

Summary

*She throws a punch that Catra dodges, gets a kick in the side for her trouble but from there Adora can grab her legs, pull her to the ground with her. Her next punch lands, Catra's punch lands, snow flies, and somewhere, Frosta is trying to put the castle back together because chunks of ice are flying up, defying gravity. Catra slips her hold and gets on one, Adora follows her and gets on another. There's a distance between them that Adora can't shrink; she can only size it up as she tries to breathe. The cold burns her lungs.*

*"You keep doing this to me," Adora says. Doesn't mean to say; it comes out anyhow.*

Notes

hello hello! welcome to my first ever catradora. i watched all of she-ra in about a week back in january and these two have been living in my head rent-free ever since. i love them. i'll note that this fic sticks very close to canon--most of the dialogue, especially in the beginning of the fic, is directly from the episode itself. all of adora's interior thoughts, however, are courtesy of yours truly, and you'll see when i start to trod off the canon path. also i did throw together a spotify playlist that's generally post-s01e01 but pre-s05e05 catradora that is hardly necessary for this fic and frankly only some of the songs apply here, but it was very helpful for me personally to have some catradora jams. they kept me in a catradora mood even when i wasn't writing it, so thank you mood music. thank you amy winehouse for "love is a losing game." thank you mitski for every song ever.

and so, without further ado...

See the end of the work for more notes

The ballroom spins worse than any out-of-control skiff Adora's ever been on, partner to partner to partner to partner. She should've practiced dancing with other people before the All Princess Ball actually started, on safer Bright Moon floors without a dress and a hair pin to worry about. Her first real dance shouldn't be in this frozen ballroom with Catra in and out of her hands, Catra like a fire in her brain even as partners switch, as Glimmer is in tears about how Bow won't want to be her friend anymore and—

"And I don't know where Scorpia is!"

Adora's stomach drops. A quick scan of the room reveals that Scorpia is *gone*, not on the dance floor or sidelines or buffet. "What? Glimmer, don't—"

The ballroom's incessant spinning twirls her away, pushes Adora into Perfuma. There's a distant crease in her usually-smooth brow, the baffled concern of someone not used to having concerns.

"Have you seen Bow?" she asks. "He went to get his cummerbund, but that was a while ago, right about the same time that Horde princess left."

As much as Adora wants to stop and figure this out (Scorpia and Bow both vanished at the same time, Glimmer doesn't know where Scorpia *is*), the obligations of the dance and the activity of the ballroom keep her stuck in motion. "Wait, do you mean Scorpia?"

And then Perfuma is gone. Back to Glimmer, who might know something, but is just as likely to not. Doesn't matter—Adora needs information. She has to take every shot she can.

"Glimmer, when did you last see Bow?"

Glimmer sniffles. "A while ago. Isn't he with Perfuma?"

"No. Perfuma says he's been gone this entire time."

And then Adora's spun right back into Catra, her sly grin and sharp claws and perfectly-tailored suit. The two of them are color-coordinated. Adora didn't even know she was going to be here, but they're color-coordinated anyhow. Easy to do in the Horde, when there were only so many colors to wear, but out here? So far from home?

"Maybe my plan won't work," Catra says lightly, starting to dip Adora. She can go with it or fall onto the unforgiving ballroom floor. Adora doesn't want to add a concussion onto the injury roster, not when her healing powers are only middling. She lets her balance shift lower, allows Catra's hand on her waist and puts her arm around her neck so that she doesn't go crashing out of her grip. They're too close, legs and torsos and faces and Catra still smells like Catra beneath the Horde-issues cologne they give out to captains for undercover missions. Catra smells like Catra in this room full of strangers and friends and allies and everybody knows, everybody has to know, her face is so *close*—

"But then again, maybe it already has."

The moment passes, the dip ends, Adora is righted and dizzy and Catra's hand is loose around her wrist, her mouth moving around words that buzz and blister and hit her a second too late—*Say, where's your friend Bow?*

Everything clicks together—Bow's disappearance, Glimmer losing sight of Scorpia, Catra's smug question. A kidnapping. Of *course*. Catra's battle plans always involve a kidnapping. Her terrible taste for drama never ends.

The only satisfaction Adora gets is the satisfaction of tackling Catra to the ground, her getting upright again only for Adora to find more momentum, to send her crashing into Frosta's delicate little ice decorations while the ballroom gasps as one. They can all see, they're all seeing, and Bow, she did something to Bow—

"What did you do to him?!"

Catra gives her the same lazy smirk she always wears when she's pleased, the one that makes her chest alight with pain. It's familiar—it's the same—Adora shivers from the heat. She's thirteen all over again, a newly-minted cadet a whole week before Catra will get the same title, feeling her run her claws over the seams of her new uniform as she waxed poetic about the word *nepotism*. Adora hadn't remembered a single thing about the word's definition, only the way Catra said it and all the horrible burning things it brought to her, the burning things still on fire.

"Nothing permanent," Catra promises.

Adora grabs her by the lapels of that dumb, perfectly-fitting jacket, brings her to eye-level. Focus. Focus. Bow, one of her best friends in the world, and Catra is the only person who knows where he is. "Tell me what you did to him right—"

No chance. Adora's in the ice trap before she even processes the words *ice trap*, kneeling on the floor in her frozen cage. Frosta's imperial anger makes her look a great deal older than eleven-and-three-quarters—Adora's stuck with the same sinking feeling she gets when Queen Angella and Shadow Weaver show their displeasure. Any alliance with Frosta is *so* over.

"Reverend Hostess," Adora starts, and is quickly cut off.

Frosta's speech on unity and non-violence falls on deaf ears. The only thing Adora can hear is Catra snickering, very quietly, very close, very pleased, and that's when the castle starts to collapse.

Then the screaming, the panic, dance shoes on ice floors and pillars collapsing to nothing more than ice blocks and snowflakes in the wind. Glimmer, somewhere, and then right there, wide-eyed with the terror—

"Catra has Bow!" She shouts. "You have to find him!"

And Glimmer is gone in a flash, leaving just Catra and Adora in a ballroom that's crumbling to pieces. Nothing Adora does gets her close to escaping her icey cage, and Catra is clearly uninterested

in helping. Just interested in kneeling in front of her, a feather-light touch on her jaw to keep Adora's eyes on her. As if she could look anywhere else.

"What did you do?"

Catra smiles, just as she's smiled at Adora a thousand times. Adora burns. Nothing ever changes with them. "I did nothing. Scorpia, Lonnie, and Kyle, on the other hand, were *very* busy. It was fun distracting you, though. Maybe we can do this some other time. I can teach you how to tango."

Adora's above biting Catra's hand, but she considers it. Considers sinking to her level because there are lives on the line, her friend's *lives*, and all she can do is flirt like this is some kind of joke, like they're back in the Horde and she's teasing because she knows, she knows, everyone must know except now everything is too real to linger on it. There's no time.

"This isn't a game! People are going to get hurt!"

"It's never been a game to me, Adora," Catra tells her. "I'm after something bigger, and no one can stop me."

"What're you after, then?"

Catra hums. "You know, I'm not one of your subjects that you can just order around. I'm not telling you."

There's a thunderous crack behind her, and Catra takes off just as the pillar comes crashing down on Adora's cage. Noise and pressure and blind grappling and Adora frees herself from the ice so cold that it burns her skin, bright red patches on her naked arms, sprints after Catra as fast as her ridiculous shoes and throbbing headache will allow. Kicks off the shoes, eventually, keeps chasing after her shadow and climbing further into the castle, up and through and then Catra, the dead end of a hallway. Stupidly, the only thing in Adora's head: *Let's tango*.

She throws a punch that Catra dodges, gets a kick in the side for her trouble but from there Adora can grab her legs, pull her to the ground with her. Her next punch lands, Catra's punch lands, snow flies, and somewhere, Frosta is trying to put the castle back together because chunks of ice are flying up, defying gravity. Catra slips her hold and gets on one, Adora follows her and gets on another. There's a distance between them that Adora can't shrink; she can only size it up as she tries to breathe. The cold burns her lungs.

"You keep doing this to me," Adora says. Doesn't mean to say; it comes out anyhow.

Catra's laugh is cheerless, merciless, stings like salt. "*I'm* doing this to *you*? Oh, you're rich. You started this!"

"I didn't—"

"You did! Sorry that you have to deal with being the asshole for once in your life, but you did this, Adora. You started it, and I'm ending it."

Catra hops off her chunk of ice and Adora tumbles after her. Stuck on some distant rooftop in some foreign land—she aches for the familiar Fright Zone roofs. Catra kicks her to the ground without the courtesy to take her hands out of her pockets for the event, dodges Adora's lunge, slams the back of her neck with an elbow and when Adora gets up, Catra dodges again. Too far, too close to the edge, loses her balance, and—

And it's instinct. Habit. They really never left the Fright Zone roofs, not when Adora reaches out to catch her, pulls her close. A smarter Adora would've let her fall, but her heart, her heart, her burning heart. Her feet frozen to the roof. She'd beat Catra bloody, has and will continue to, but she'd never let her fall.

Catra throws herself forward. Adora braces for headbutt and gets a kiss instead. A kiss? A kiss, definitely, lips to Adora's lips and hands on her shoulders and the world collapses, shrinks to Catra

and lips and the edge of the roof. There's no other living soul, not Glimmer or Bow or Scorpia or Lonnie or Shadow Weaver. Even Hordak fades when Catra pulls back, starts to laugh, to say something. Hell if she knows what.

Adora chases the noise without a second thought, kisses her with the force of a bullet, a hydrogen bomb, a flower blooming through the flames of their lives here in this kingdom of ice. She has wanted and she wants and she will want and her nose aches like she's caught one of Rogellio's right hooks because of the angle she grabbed, but she can't stop, won't stop, doesn't know how to stop now that she's finally been allowed to start. It was Catra who started this—it's Adora who will end it.

Catra wrestles control of the angle from her, puts a hand on her face to twist it into something less painful. Air is a secondary concern, the only thing that matters is that Catra is kissing her, that she opens her mouth and Adora cuts her lips on her fangs, blood between them sweeter than any All Princess Ball wine. Years of wanting, years of it, and if Catra is kissing her back, if Catra is with her—there's a chance. A shadow of a chance. Maybe. The kisses trail down her neck, and Catra *bites* in a way that makes her moan, compels her to pull her closer. There are words. There must be words. Adora can't think of them, can only think of the relief of Catra and closer and Catra, Catra, Catra. This can be fixed. This has to be fixed. There is something here left to save.

The shuddering of the castle coming together jostles them both off of the roof, kissing to screaming to the unforgiving cliffs and Adora's pin, her stupid hair pin. It'll have to be enough. She pulls it out and slides it against the ice. Catra grabs her wrist, and they skid to a stop, dangling what must be a mile above the ground. Adora's ponytail is ruined, hair free and flying in the wind. The cold bites her clear through except for where Catra's claws are digging into her wrist. There's warmth there—blood, from how hard she's holding on.

"We can fix this," Adora says. "I can get us out of here, and then we can fix this. Catra, please, I know we can—We've always—I

always wanted you with me—”

Her claws dig deeper into Adora’s skin, deep enough that she yelps. It stops her dead.

“Really? One little kiss is all it takes for reconciliation to be back on the table? Oh, Adora,” she sighs. Adora looks down. Catra’s smiling, but her eyes are flat and cold. She’s never seen her so unhappy. “You make it so easy.”

She lets go, drops into the abyss of the sky and Adora shrieks, wild and inconsolable as blood drips down her wrist, blood stains her mouth, her own grip on her hair pin gets shakier. Catra, Catra, Catra, and the sound of skiff starting below her. Just below her, now, visible, with Catra climbing in through the top.

Of course. Of course. *You make it so easy.* It might not be a game, but it was a tactic. Even if it didn’t start at one, that’s how it ended up. A winning tactic. Even if Catra’s the only one who saw the worst of it, even if she’s the only one who knows, *she knows*.

As the skiff gets closer, Adora spots Bow and Glimmer, unconscious. Scorpia and Kyle and Lonnie, very conscious, with her sword, and now Catra, safe inside the skiff when Adora thought she was plummeting to her death. A nasty trick, the kind of trick she always plays. Catra does this, and Adora forgives her because she can’t help it, it’s Catra and she can never help it, and then she does it again. Nothing changes except for the stakes, and Adora’s put her heart up for play. Her friend’s lives up for play. Poor Catra; she’ll never hate Adora as much as Adora despises herself now, looking at her kidnapped friend and stolen sword and the proud owner of her own burning heart, delivered to her on an icy platter. She’ll never come close.

“See you around, princess,” Catra says through the intercom system.

Adora watches their ship leave as she dangles from her own hair pin down the steep castle cliff. There's a distinct frostbite setting in on the bottoms of her feet and a distinct fire inside her mouth, around her wrist, on her neck and in her chest. She's here, and part of her will always be here, dangling by her own hair pin with the taste of blood in her mouth. There are places you go where no one can follow, Shadow Weaver told her once. There are places you can go that you can't tell anyone you've ever been. There are places where even the people you meet will never know how you were there and what it meant to you. It is unsayable. It is impossible. It's not to be beheld. And it can be ignored, but it can't be left behind.

So when her rescue mission arrives, Perfuma and Entrapta and Mermista and Seahawk and a skiff, Adora does her duty; she goes, but she doesn't leave.

End Notes

my twitter
my tumblr

over futile odds.....and laughed at by the gods.....and now the final frame.....love.....is a losing gameeeeeee

(also thank you to john steinbeck for the full quote that makes up this title: "all great and precious things are lonely.")

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